Bending the Iron Triangle

Oct 1, 2026 · @Lekhyasri Pandavula

Turning a Halfway Change Request into a Deal Everyone Signed

A scenario-based project management case study. All organizations, people and figures are fictional.

Halfway through a six-month app project, the sponsor asked for six new features with no extra budget and no change to the launch date. This case study shows how I assessed the impact, negotiated a trade the sponsor could accept, and won approval from every stakeholder who needed to agree, without compromising quality.

At a glance

- **My role:** Project manager.
- **The project:** Castle brook Connect, a £120,000 patient booking app for 14 dental clinics.
- **The challenge:** At the halfway point, the sponsor requested six new features worth £30,000, with no extra budget and no delay.
- **What I did:** Logged a formal change request, assessed the impact with the delivery team, presented options in the sponsor's own terms, negotiated a trade and took it through steering committee approval.
- **The result:** All six features delivered, two in simplified form, for £8,000 more and three weeks later, with full user testing kept. The app beat its main success target within eight weeks of launch.

The project

Castle brook Dental Group runs 14 clinics across the South of England. Its reception teams spent much of each day on the phone booking appointments, which meant long waits for callers and less attention for patients at the desk.

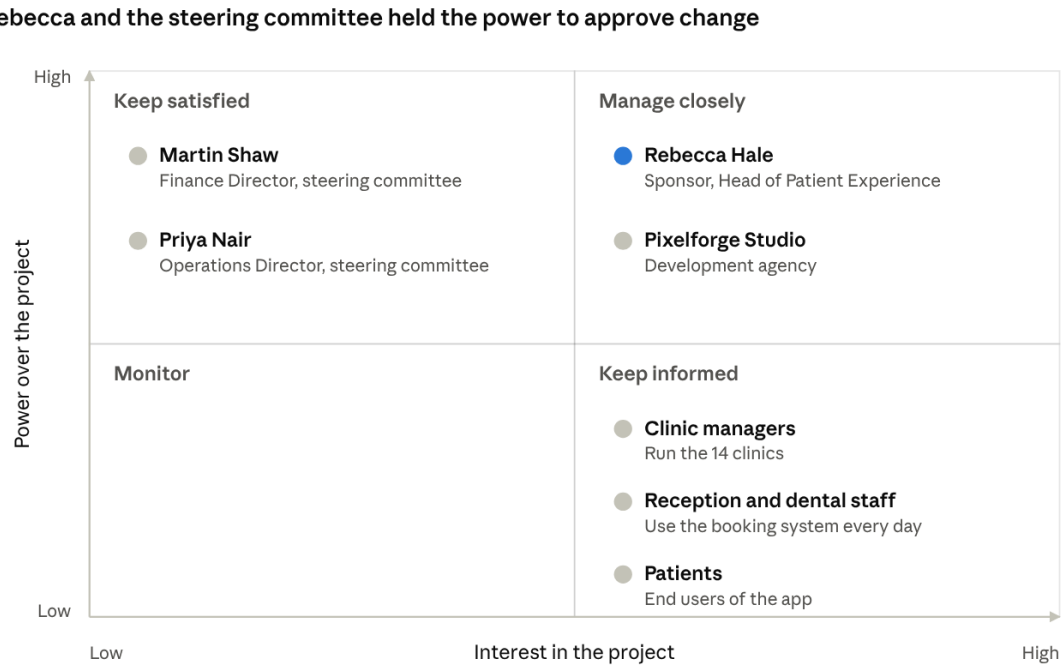
In January 2026 we agreed a six-month project to build Castle brook Connect, an app that lets patient book, change and cancel appointments online. I was the project manager, leading a business analyst, a part-time UX designer and Pixel forge Studio, the development agency. Rebecca Hale, Head of Patient Experience, was the project sponsor and signed off the charter summarized below.

Table 1: The agreed baseline

Area	Agreed in the project charter
Scope	Patient app for online booking, rescheduling and cancelling across 14 clinics
Budget	£120,000, including £10,000 contingency
Timeline	26 weeks, 5 January to 6 July 2026
Quality	Four weeks of user testing before launch
Success measures	85% of online bookings completed with no phone call; 30% fewer phone bookings within three months; app rating of 4.5 or above
Governance	Fortnightly steering committee (Rebecca Hale, Finance Director Martin Shaw, Operations Director Priya Nair) approves any change to budget or launch date

The stakeholders

Before work began, I mapped every stakeholder by their power over the project and their interest in it. That map set how closely I engaged each group, and it became essential when the change request arrived: it told me whose approval I needed, and who would feel the impact.



Stakeholder power/interest grid · 7 stakeholders in 3 groups

Rebecca and the steering committee could approve or block any change, so I managed them closely and kept them satisfied. Clinic teams and patients would live with the result, so I kept them informed at every stage.

Table 2: The communication plan agreed at the start

Stakeholder	What they need to know	Channel	Frequency
Rebecca Hale (sponsor)	Progress, risks and decisions needed	1:1 meeting and status report	Weekly
Steering committee	Budget, milestones and change approvals	Steering meeting	Fortnightly
Pixel forge Studio	Priorities, scope and changes	Stand-ups and sprint planning	Daily and fortnightly
Clinic managers	Launch timing, training and impact on staff	Teams update	Monthly
Reception and dental staff	Training and go-live support	Training sessions and FAQ	Before launch
Patients	Launch news and how to use the app	Email, SMS and in-clinic posters	At launch

The change request

On 30 March 2026, three months in, the project was on schedule and on budget, with £60,000 spent. That week a rival dental chain launched its own app with live chat and online payments. Rebecca asked for six new features to match it, on one condition: the budget and the 6 July launch date could not move.

I didn't agree or refuse on the spot. I logged the request as change request CR-004 and committed to returning within three days with a full impact assessment. With Pixel forge, I estimated each feature's cost and checked its effect on testing and the launch date.

Table 3: Impact of the requested features

Requested feature	Cost
SMS appointment reminders	£2,000
Family accounts (book for children)	£3,000
Waiting list for earlier slots	£3,000
Live chat with a dentist	£10,000

Requested feature	Cost
In-app payments and deposits	£7,000
Video consultations	£5,000
Total cost of the six features	**£30,000**
Less: remaining contingency	−£10,000
Budget increase needed	**£20,000**
Timeline impact	**+6 weeks (launch moves to 17 August)**

The contingency covered only a third of the cost. The two most expensive features, live chat and video consultations, accounted for half of it.

Presenting the options

On 2 April I met Rebecca face to face with the impact assessment. I framed each option around her goal, winning patients back from the competitor, and the success measures she had signed off in the charter.

- **Option 1: absorb everything.** Fitting six features into the same budget and date meant cutting user testing from four weeks to one. Features nobody had properly tested would go live to patients at 14 clinics. That put the 85% booking target at serious risk and could hand the competitor the very advantage she wanted to prevent.
- **Option 2: deliver everything properly.** All six features in full, with testing protected, would raise the budget to £140,000 and move the launch to 17 August, six weeks late.

Option 1 risked quality; Option 2 risked the timing she cared about. Neither gave her what she actually needed: a reliable app in patients' hands as soon as possible.

The negotiation

The negotiation took a week and two meetings, and it turned on one question: what did Rebecca actually need?

Rebecca rejected both options. The board would not approve more money, she said, and a late launch would hand the summer to the competitor.

Holding the line without saying no. I acknowledged the pressure she was under and agreed the threat was real. But I was clear: all six features on time and on budget meant cutting testing, and I would not recommend an untested launch. Then I asked what worried her most about the competitor.

Finding the interest behind the position. Her position was all six features, for the same money, by the same date. Her interest was keeping patients and avoiding a launch that failed in public. Once we both saw that, we were solving the same problem instead of arguing over a number.

Offering a trade. On 6 April I proposed a third option: keep four features in full and simplify the two most expensive.

- Live chat with a dentist (£10,000) becomes a callback request (£2,000): patients ask for a call and a dental nurse ring back.
- Video consultations (£5,000) become a link to the video tool the clinics already use (£1,000).

In-app payments stayed in full, because deposits reduce missed appointments. The trade cut the cost of the new features from £30,000 to £18,000 and the delay from six weeks to three. After the contingency, the ask fell from £20,000 and six weeks to £8,000 and three.

Testing the trade with the people it affected. A callback feature risked adding phone work for reception, the very problem the app was built to solve. Before proposing it, I agreed with Operations Director Priya Nair that dental nurses would handle callbacks in a fixed daily slot. Pixel forge confirmed the revised estimates in writing.

Making yes easy. Rebecca accepted the trade but was still reluctant to ask for more money. So, I did the groundwork for her: an updated change request, a one-page business case, and a briefing for Finance Director Martin Shaw on 7 April so the numbers held no surprises. On 9 April we presented it together, and the steering committee approved it.

The agreed deal

Change request CR-004 was approved on 9 April 2026: all six features, two in simplified form, for £8,000 more and three weeks later, with full user testing kept.

Table 4: The original plan, the sponsor's request and the agreed deal

	Original plan	Rebecca's request	Agreed deal
Scope	Core booking app	Plus six features all in full	Plus, six features, two simplified
Budget	£120,000	£120,000 (no increase)	£128,000
Launch date	6 July 2026	6 July 2026	27 July 2026
User testing	Four weeks	Cut to one week	Four weeks, kept in full

Communicating the decision

I sequenced the announcement so that nobody heard the news second-hand, and each group heard what it meant for them.

- **Rebecca:** written confirmation of the decision, the new baseline and her actions, the same afternoon.

- **Pixel forge Studio:** a briefing the next morning on the revised backlog and the protected four-week testing window.
- **Clinic managers:** a special update the following week, rather than waiting for the monthly one, covering the new 27 July launch date and what the callback feature meant for their teams.
- **Dental nurses:** a short briefing on handling callbacks, added to the pre-launch training plan.

I also updated the RAID log. With the contingency used up, I logged the loss of our buffer as a high risk and agreed a change freeze from week 16, so no further requests could reopen the scope.

Results

Castle brook Connect launched on 27 July 2026 with all six features and four full weeks of user testing behind it. Within eight weeks it had already beaten its main target.

Table 5: Results after eight weeks

Success measure	Target	After eight weeks
Online bookings completed with no phone call	85%	88%
Reduction in phone bookings	30% within three months	24%, on track
App store rating	4.5 or above	4.6

Final spends came in at £128,000, exactly the approved budget, with no further changes after the freeze. Rebecca has since asked me to run Phase 2, using the same change process from day one.

What I would do differently

- **Ring-fence a change budget.** A small budget for changes, separate from contingency, would give mid-project requests a funded route without using up the safety margin.
- **Treat competitors as a risk from the start.** Logging competitor launches in the RAID log at kickoff would have made this request an anticipated risk rather than a surprise.
- **Involve Finance earlier.** Briefing Martin Shaw before the steering meeting made approval straightforward, so next time I would involve him as soon as a change touches the budget.

Skills demonstrated

Table 6: Where each skill shows

Skill	Where it shows
Stakeholder analysis	Mapped every stakeholder by power and interest before the project began
Communication planning	Tailored channel and frequency to each group, and sequenced how the decision was announced
Change control	Logged CR-004 formally instead of agreeing on the spot, then re-baselined and froze scope
Impact assessment	Costed each feature with the delivery team and showed the effect on budget, time and quality
Negotiation	Separated the sponsor's position from her interest, then traded scope for a smaller increase in time and money
Governance	Took the decision through the steering committee, with the Finance Director briefed in advance
Quality management	Protected four weeks of user testing throughout

The triangle bent, but it didn't break. Scope, time and cost each gave a little, and quality- the one thing patients would actually notice, stayed intact.